



GOVERNMENT BENEFITS • INSIGHT

Denied Social Security Disability? Here's What Actually Happens Next

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Getting denied for Social Security disability the first time you apply is common, not a sign your case is weak. Most initial applications are denied nationwide, and the process that follows is where a real case actually gets built.

A denial is a stage, not the end of the road

After an initial denial, you generally have two paths depending on your state: a reconsideration request, or moving directly to a hearing. Both come with strict deadlines, typically 60 days from the date of the denial notice, and missing that window can mean starting the entire application over.

The hearing stage is where most approvals happen

A hearing in front of an Administrative Law Judge is where claimants have historically had their best chance of approval. This is also where medical evidence, work history, and a clear presentation of how your condition limits you matter most. It is worth preparing for like the significant event it is.

SSDI and SSI are not the same program

SSDI is based on your work history and the taxes you have paid into the system. SSI is needs-based, tied to limited income and resources regardless of work history. Some people qualify for both, and the paperwork, evidence, and eligibility rules differ for each.

Veterans have a separate, parallel system

VA disability claims run through the Department of Veterans Affairs, not the Social Security Administration, and use their own rating system tied to degree of service-connected disability. A denial or an unfairly low rating can often be appealed, including through the Board of Veterans' Appeals.

Whatever program you are dealing with, deadlines are the single most common way a valid claim gets lost. If you have received a denial notice, the clock is already running, and it is worth having someone look at your file before that window closes.

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